

This, that, and it

Learner workbook

Refer clearly to objects and ideas in context.

Understand the distinction

This and that can point to objects or refer to ideas. This often presents something as near or currently in focus; that can refer back or suggest greater distance. The distance may be physical, conversational, or emotional.

Either speaker can use this or that. There is no rule that this must refer to your own idea and that to someone else's. It often continues a reference to an identified thing or situation. Name the idea again when a pronoun would be unclear.

Compare the patterns

IN FOCUS

This is my main concern: the cost.

This introduces the idea in focus.

REFER BACK

I missed the train. That made me late.

The same speaker refers back to their own statement.

CONTINUE

I bought a bag. It is very light.

It continues the reference to the bag.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Can the same speaker say I lost my key. That was frustrating?

- A. No. That can only refer to a physical object.
- B. No. That can only refer to someone else's event.
- C. Yes. That can refer back to the speaker's own event.

2. What does it refer to in I found a notebook. It was empty?

- A. The person who found it.
- B. The act of finding it.
- C. The notebook.

3. Improve the unclear It was a problem after mentioning two possible problems.

- A. That was a problem.
- B. Name the problem, for example: The missing address was a problem.
- C. It was definitely a problem.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. A canceled bus made you walk home. Which pair refers clearly to that event and its consequence?

- A. The bus was canceled. That meant I had to walk home.
- B. The bus was delayed. That meant I had to walk home.
- C. The bus was canceled and the taxi was late. It meant I had to walk home.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. Yes. That can refer back to the speaker's own event.

Pronoun choice is not determined by who first mentioned the idea.

2. C. The notebook.

It continues an identified reference.

3. B. Name the problem, for example: The missing address was a problem.

A noun phrase removes the ambiguous reference.

4. A. The bus was canceled. That meant I had to walk home.

That refers back to the cancellation event.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-28.html